

Course PC 748**INTRODUCTION TO DESIGN HISTORY****Instructor - Prof. Madhumita Mazumdar****COURSE INSTRUCTOR-** Prof. Madhumita Mazumdar

Course Objective : This course will introduce students to the emergent field of Design History or Design Studies as a part of a broader attempt to instill in students a critical engagement with their discipline. It will map the evolution of interest in 'historical' questions related to Design both as practice and as discipline. But before that we will try to understand the many meanings of Design in use and ask which one of these helps us understand the true nature of our practice.

Course Structure:

The course will introduce students to the range of approaches to the study of the History of Design- particularly conventional, narrative approaches to Design History and conceptual and critical approaches to the same.

Students would be able to make the distinction between practice and discipline even if both are interlinked in order to understand how historians have approached the subject of their study. The module will also include an important connecting thread in the History of Design- that of the larger economic, social, political and cultural contexts within which Design took shape both as practice

and as pedagogy. So there will be two entangled strands of historical inquiry we will follow- one following the development of Design and the other looking at the global and national contexts that shaped it.

These global contexts are indicated by such historical periodizations such as the Industrial Revolution, the first Great War and the rise of Communism in Russia, the inter-war years, the rise of Fascism the Cold War era, the era of Mass Consumption, the Counter-Culture and the contemporary era of Globalization.

The final segment of the course will turn to India and look at **colonial context in which India found itself during the period of the Industrial Revolution**. We will see how the first consciousness of an Indian-designed and made products was emerging in the context of the Swadeshi movement in 1905-1911, the impact of the emergence of Gandhi in sensitizing us to the power of Design in nationalist politics and finally we will look into the ways in which both modern western Design practice and pedagogy as well as our own craft traditions and material culture served to shape the context within which India's first modern Design school was established in 1961.

Course Outcome : Toward the end of the course, we will try to understand how Design history helps us engage with questions of form, function and aesthetics in completely different ways and generate new ways of looking at the products and services they consume as part of our everyday lives. They will seek to understand how does Design History prompt us to question the larger implications of what we buy or use in terms of the impacts these have on human health and wellbeing, on the built environment and the planet at large.

There will be continuous evaluation of students through class participation, individual presentations and a final research paper, seminar or in-class examination.

Selected Readings from:

Nikolaus Pevsner, *Pioneers of Modern Design* (1936; revised ed. 1960)

John Heskett, *Industrial Design* (1980) and *Design: A Very Short Introduction* (2002)

Jonathan Woodham, *Twentieth Century Design* (1997)

Victor Margolin, *World History of Design* (2015, 2 vols.)

H.K. Kumar Vyas : *Alternative Histories of Design* (essays)

S. Balaram : *Thinking Design*